

China Healthcare

Global China Summit Takeaways (Day 2): AI applications in early and late drug development; China pharma panel

Day 2 key takeaways are: 1) WuXi AppTec reiterated its FY26E guidance, but we expect potential raise; 2) XtalPi is expanding its AI-driven drug discovery ecosystem through flexible partnerships and automated lab capabilities; 3) Tigermed is actively integrating AI across its clinical operations to optimize costs and address ongoing pricing pressures; 4) Yifeng's same-store sales recovery is on track, with management guiding to 5%+ SSG (same store growth) in 2026; 5) Innovent's management expressed confidence in achieving a CAGR of 15%~20% from 2027-2030.

- WuXi AppTec reiterated its FY2026 guidance, driving growth through its “R”, “D”, and “M” business while managing geopolitical noise.** Capturing strong China and overseas demand, its “R” related business could grow at single digit and TIDES (oligonucleotides and peptides) business is projected to grow at 40% for FY26E. While the US BIOSECURE Act remains a geopolitical “elephant in the room,” management does not see customers specifically asking about the Biosecure Act and is not aware of updates on the execution of the Biosecure Act. Management suggests capex will likely increase in the future for capacity expansion. The recent issue of Rmb6.78bn is to raise more cash for capacity expansion, where the money spent on domestic capacity expansion will be roughly equal to that spent on overseas capacity expansion. We have an interesting observation that many investors at the group meeting appear new to the WuXi AppTec story.
- XtalPi is expanding its AI-driven drug discovery ecosystem through flexible partnerships and automated lab capabilities.** The company operates on a diversified business model that utilizes both fee-for-service (FFS) and royalty-based agreements, while broadening its capabilities into new therapeutic modalities like siRNA and peptides. Drug discovery work is supported by 24/7 automated labs and the METiS drug delivery platform, which helps accelerate the process from hit identification to preclinical candidates (PCC) to 12 to 18 months, according to the company. The company continues to see strong business development (BD) momentum alongside recovery in venture capital (VC) funding environment.
- Tigermed is actively integrating AI across its clinical operations to optimize costs and address ongoing pricing pressures.** The company reiterated its double-digit growth target for this year. The company is applying AI to labor-intensive tasks such as medical writing, translation, and biostatistics, targeting 20% automation in writing and translation, as well as 20% to 30% efficiency gains for Clinical Research Associates (CRAs) and Source Document Verification (SDV). Standardizing through these AI capabilities is helping the company create cost-center efficiencies and navigate an increasingly commoditized clinical research organization (CRO) market.
- Yifeng's same-store sales recovery is on track, with management guiding to 5%+ SSG in 2026.** Sustained recovery is underpinned by: 1) regulatory normalization of inspections entering third year, with inspection coverage expanding to smaller independent pharmacy stores and thereby diluting

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pressure on large chains; 2) a clear retreat from irrational price competition among chains; and 3) a more efficient store network following the closure of ~2,000 underperforming stores in 2024–25. The April 2026 inspection incident involves a single franchisee store with Rmb 243 in payment irregularities and is already resolved. The non-pharma product category pilot program (105 stores in 2025, targeting 1,000 by end-2026) is an optionality lever that the market has largely under-appreciated. By deploying 30-40% idle staff time and ~50% unused floor space at near-zero incremental fixed cost, the non-pharma business is directly accretive to the store economics.

- **Innovent’s management expressed confidence in achieving CAGR of 15%~20% from 2027-2030.** On financials, the company suggested that FY26E profit margin might continue to improve. The FY27E revenue target of Rmb 20 bn does not include multiple late-stage assets including IBI363, IBI343, HER2 ADC, XO1, and two ophthalmic VEGF products efdamrofusp (IBI302) and IBI324, therefore the approval of these assets will provide sufficient impetus to 2027-2030 growth runway; the 2030-2035 period represents a second growth phase driven by overseas product launches, where IBI363’s two lung cancer indications alone are modeled to generate several billion dollars in sales at higher margin profiles. For mazdutide, 2026 is explicitly a market share land-grab year ahead of a materially more competitive 2027 landscape when semaglutide biosimilars and domestic peers (Hengrui, Hansoh) enter. Innovent is deliberately sacrificing near-term profitability to build brand equity, targeting at least Rmb5 bn GLP-1 contribution to the 2027 target. On IBI363, the ASCO 2026 first-line dose-optimization Ph1 readout and the potential FDA greenlight on second-line non-squamous NSCLC Ph3 design are the two near-term catalysts. In addition, Olin plans to launch at least one Ph3 trial of IBI324 in 2H26. Takeda’s new CEO visited Innovent earlier this year, suggesting Takeda could continue to value the importance of IBI363 partnership.
- **Transformation of China Pharma panel with Hengrui and GeneScience: All in innovation and globalization.** Chinese biotech and pharma’s out-licensing is accelerating faster than expected, with BD deal volume on pace to double in 2026 versus 2025, and the quality of that expansion is also improving. Companies are no longer simply selling early-stage assets for upfront cash, but they are increasingly co-developing products with overseas partners, retaining meaningful economics, and using the partnerships to absorb commercial and regulatory know-how they don’t yet have internally. On R&D, Hengrui is converging on two practical filters that have replaced the first-in-class versus best-in-class debate: does the drug address a genuine unmet need, and is it clearly better than what already exists. GeneScience shows a trend toward targeting disease areas that have seen no meaningful therapeutic progress in decades, moving away from the crowded oncology and immunology targets. On BD, the emerging industry consensus is that licensing out early-stage assets is a practical way to monetize early-stage assets, given that most early-stage drug candidates fail. MNC’s market access experience and regulatory expertise also accelerate the path to overseas approval and maximize asset value. Partner selection is increasingly sophisticated, with companies matching deal structure to partner type. For example, choosing therapeutic-area leaders for outright asset out-licensing, pipeline-complementary partners for strategic co-cos, and capital-rich companies for NewCo structures. On geopolitical risk, the consistent industry response is portfolio geographic diversification, proactive ex-China clinical trial initiation to pre-empt potential FDA data recognition issues, retaining China rights in all outbound deals as a stable earnings anchor, and positioning Chinese companies as collaborative partners in overseas markets rather than disruptive new entrants.

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